black duffel bag with him. Dhanu and Shubha would rarely step out of the house, except to go cycling on their BSA SLRs in the evening dressed in churidar kameez. They would never go shopping. The broker who got them the house would buy them the things they needed.'

Esylen said that one day four people—two men and two women—came in two autorickshaws to her neighbouring house. She learnt then that they had taken the house on rent and that their names were Dhanu, Shubha, Nero and Sivarasan. They had brought a TV with them, the antenna of which they fixed on the terrace. However, they also put up two casuarina tree posts connected with a black wire. This raised her suspicions. Why would an ordinary family require such things? On the fateful day, Esylen claimed to have seen Sivarasan, Shubha and Dhanu waiting at the bus stand in her colony. And the very next day, Esylen watched the news of Rajiv Gandhi's assassination on television. She caught a glimpse of her new neighbours again after five days. But she could not spot Dhanu among them. She was looking for her in particular following the publication of her photograph in newspapers that morning. She understood it was the same girl she had seen at the bus stand. Esylen saw Sivarasan's photograph in the newspaper three days later. She immediately understood that her neighbours were the killers of Rajiv Gandhi. She said that she was scared to even think about it. Her hands had started shaking when she found out. About one week after that, Vijayan came to her house and borrowed a driller. He said he wanted to fix a fan regulator.

Esylen, scared yet curious, went to her neighbour's house to ask for the driller back.

She saw Sivarasan standing in the hall. This time he was not wearing his glasses. He stood there with his left eye shut. But Esylen, whether in person or in photographs, had always seen him in glasses. She dared to ask Selvaluxmi what happened to his eye. She said he had lost it while playing. Esylen again realized she was shaking as she realized she was looking at one of the world's biggest fugitives standing right in front of her. If she was terrified on the one hand, she also could not resist finding out more about him on the other.